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(AI-Generated Session Notes)

Entity-Led Digital PR Workflows: Using Commentary, AI Prompts, and Media Partnerships to Build SME Authority in Search

Date & time: Oct. 15, 10:00-10:35 AM
Track: Applied AI



Nicole Franco

Head of Digital PR, AI Innovation, Fractl

- LinkedIn

Session Description

In this talk, Nicole Franco will share the outreach process, AI prompt stacks, and sample pitch templates her team uses to turn thought leaders and their brands into high-authority entities that earn links and visibility across Google and LLMs like ChatGPT. You'll see how commentary can be scaled as a structured data asset, how to target AI-priority publishers through media partnerships, and how to systematize the process using agentic PR workflows that generate brand visibility across traditional search engines and LLMs alike.

Learn how to build SME authority in search using entity-led digital PR. Franco will share AI prompt stacks, pitch templates, and proprietary data on which publishers influence AI visibility. Plus real case studies showing several top-tier media coverage that has been secured.

Key Quote

> *"It's building a brand so powerful that these LLMs have no choice but to cite you."* **- Nicole Franco**

Session Summary

Nicole Franco, Head of Digital PR and AI Innovation at Fractl, brought eight years of earned media experience to a session on how brands can show up inside AI-generated answers. She noted that audiences increasingly skip past Google's AI overviews or go straight to LLMs like ChatGPT and Claude, so the goal now is to put your brand at the center of that answer. Franco defined a brand's entity as the brand together with its content, its subject matter experts, and its product or service.

Franco grounded the talk in research. She cited an Ahrefs study of 75,000 brands that found branded web mentions had the highest influence on brands appearing in AI overviews. Fractl's own studies found that original research is a strong factor, that top-tier outlets such as Forbes, the New York Times, Reuters, and the BBC appear repeatedly across LLMs, and that vertical-specific publishers matter too. In an analysis of 11,000 prompts, 74% of software-buying answers

cited at least one review and comparison platform. Her conclusion: map the questions, find the citations, and identify the gaps.

She then walked through ways to mobilize an entity: commentary-led, product-led, and data-led campaigns, combined into what she calls the ultimate media engine. Case studies included Payless Power, whose CEO became a go-to source and whose AI visibility nearly tripled; Paint Me Like, which saw an 800% increase in AI impressions through hyper-specific gift and experience stories; and Fractl's own AI psychosis research, which earned coverage in Newsweek, Fox News, and CNBC and was then extended through commentary, podcasts, and social. As a result, Fractl saw increases in AI mentions, AI answers, and organic search.

On execution, Franco stressed that every pitch must be surprising, timely, and backed by data or subject matter experts. She shared a prompt approach that scans news from the last 24 to 48 hours, social listening, and journalist queries, illustrated by a trend-driven weight loss pitch that produced about 20 original stories. She also showed how she uses ChatGPT deep research to build hyper-specific media lists, Claude projects loaded with each entity's data and commentary, and AI to duplicate the structure of proven pitches while keeping a human in the loop.

Franco closed with a five-step AI workflow: give AI context, research and match, build and draft, review and refine, and save and reuse. Her call to action was to find one gap, bring something useful, and build a repeatable workflow, arguing that the future of search is not keywords or links but a brand authoritative enough that LLMs cite it.

Key Takeaways

- **Third-party citations shape AI visibility:** Branded web mentions had the highest influence on AI overview appearances in the Ahrefs study Franco cited, making earned media from top-tier and vertical-specific publishers a core search strategy.
- **Know what AI cites in your category:** Because citation sources vary by vertical, such as review and comparison platforms in software buying, brands should map the questions, find the citations, and target the gaps.
- **Mobilize your brand, product, and people:** Data-led, product-led, and commentary-led campaigns build the most authority when combined and repurposed across podcasts, video, and social as one media engine.
- **Pitch stories, not promotions:** Journalists need surprising, timely, emotion-driven stories backed by data or experts, so a pitch sent after the moment has passed will not get covered.
- **Use AI to move at the speed of news:** Prompts that scan the last 24 to 48 hours of news, social conversations, and journalist queries help teams spot opportunities early, and deep research tools can build hyper-specific media lists.
- **Build an engine, not one-off campaigns:** Follow the five-step workflow of giving AI context, researching and matching, drafting, refining with a human touch, and saving and reusing so the team is ready when opportunities arise.